THE WAR FOR SICILY

WHEN THE PEOPLE OF SICILY rose in rebellion against their hated ruler Charles of Anjou in 1282, King Peter III of Aragon landed troops in Sicily to fight the Angevins. The complex conflict that followed the uprising known as the "Sicilian Vespers" brought a number of naval engagements, from the battle of Malta in 1283 to Ponza in 1300, in which Aragonese admiral Roger di Lauria proved himself a ruthless master of galley warfare. The war ended in 1302 with the Aragonese in control of Sicily and the Angevins ruling Naples and southern Italy.

WAR OF THE SICILIAN VESPERS 1282—1302

Southern Italy and Sicily had been part of the domains of Holy Roman Emperor Frederick II. When he died in 1250, the papacy was determined that the kingdom should not pass to his heirs and in 1265 gave it to Charles of Anjou, brother of Louis IX of France (St Louis).

KEY

- Kingdom of Sicily (to House of Anjou) 1282
- Kingdom of Aragon
- Route of Aragonese invasion
- Aragonese victory over the Angevins
- Aragonese–Angevin victory over Sicily



WAR OF THE SICILIAN VESPERS

GULF OF NAPLES



Date June 5, 1284
Forces Aragonese: 36 galleys; Angevins: c.30 galleys
Losses Aragonese: unknown; Angevins: c.12 galleys captured

Location Gulf of Naples, Italy

The victory of the Aragonese fleet at Malta in 1283 gave Admiral Roger di Lauria a temporary naval superiority he was eager to exploit. Charles of Salerno, Charles of Anjou's son, was in command in Naples, capital of the mainland half of the kingdom of Sicily. In spring 1284 Charles of Anjou was preparing to send powerful naval reinforcements to Naples. Di Lauria took his fleet to blockade the city, hoping to provoke Charles of Salerno into sending his galleys out to fight before reinforcements arrived.

Charles of Anjou had given his son strict instructions to avoid a sea battle, but the young man was impetuous and eager to demonstrate his courage and fighting prowess. He was humiliated to stand by passively as di Lauria's fleet captured incoming ships and carried out raids around Naples. On June 5 the Aragonese admiral succeeded in luring Charles of Salerno out of harbor with the apparent offer of an easy victory. Making a conspicuous show of sending a dozen of his galleys away to the south, di Lauria approached the harbor with a weakened force. Charles could not resist the temptation to engage a numerically inferior enemy and led his Neapolitan and Provencal galleys out to attack. Di Lauria turned and fled southward with Charles in pursuit.

As the galleys approached Castellammare the trap was sprung. The group of Aragonese galleys that had sailed southward rejoined the main body of di Lauria's ships. The opposing forces were now roughly equal in numbers, but the Aragonese were far superior in organization and fighting experience. Forming a crescent in line abreast, they turned and bore down on Charles's galleys, which had been pursuing in no particular formation. The Neapolitan galleys had lagged behind and were thus able to flee in disorderly fashion back to the harbor. The Provencal galleys, including Charles's own ship, were outflanked and attacked from the sides and rear. Outnumbered and outfought, the galleys were captured after a short, sharp action. Charles's ship was the last to surrender, deluged with the bolts of the Catalan crossbowmen and assailed by combat swimmers.

The capture of Charles was the crucial outcome of a victory otherwise lacking in strategic significance. He was carried off to Aragon, where he was held prisoner until 1288. He was then released after swearing that he would cede Sicily to the Aragonese, but this was a promise he felt free to renounce once he had returned to Naples.



Coronation of Charles of Anjou
This French manuscript illumination shows Charles arriving in Rome by sea in 1265 and being crowned king of Naples and Sicily by Pope Clement IV.

The Gulf of Naples
The spectacular bay dominated by Mount Vesuvius was the scene of three of Roger di Lauria's great naval victories, the first being over Charles of Anjou's son Charles of Salerno in 1284.